

LECHEN ZHANG

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EDUCATION

University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign

Jan. 2026 – Dec. 2029 (Expected)

PhD in Computer Science | GPA: 4.00/4.00

- **Advisor:** Prof. [Tal August](#)

University of Michigan, Ann Arbor

Aug. 2022 – May. 2024

Master in Information Science | GPA: 4.00/4.00 | *Distinguished Thesis*

- **Advisor:** Prof. [David Jurgens](#) and Prof. [Lu Wang](#)
- **Related coursework:** Applied Data Science (A+), Information Retrieval (A+), Game Theory (A+), Math for Data Science (A+), Big Data Analytics (A+), NLP Algorithm (A), Machine Learning (A)

Shanghai Jiao Tong University

Sep. 2019 – Aug. 2023

Bachelor in Electrical and Computer Engineering

- **Related coursework:** Computer Vision (A), Computer Architecture (A), Intro to Linguistics (A)

WORK EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant

May. 2024 – Aug. 2025

Advisor: Prof. [David Jurgens](#) and Prof. [Lu Wang](#)

University of Michigan

PUBLICATIONS

* indicates equal contribution

Peer-Reviewed Papers

[12] **SPRIG: Improving Large Language Model Performance by System Prompt Optimization**

[Lechen Zhang](#), Tolga Ergen, Lajanugen Logeswaran, Moontae Lee, David Jurgens

ICLR 2026 | Project Leader [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Slides\]](#) [\[Code\]](#) [\[Twitter\]](#)

[11] **Skill-Aware Data Selection and Fine-Tuning for Data-Efficient Reasoning Distillation**

[Lechen Zhang](#), Yunxiang Zhang, Wei Hu, Lu Wang

ACL 2026 Oral | MATH-AI Workshop @ NeurIPS 2025 | Project Leader [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)

[10] **Real or Robotic? Assessing Whether LLMs Accurately Simulate Qualities of Human Responses in Dialogue**

Jonathan Ivey*, Shivani Kumar*, Jiayu Liu*, Hua Shen*, Sushrita Rakshit*, Rohan Raju*, Haotian Zhang*, Aparna Ananthasubramaniam*, Junghwan Kim*, Bowen Yi*, Dustin Wright*, Abraham Israeli*, Anders Giovanni Møller*, [Lechen Zhang](#)*, David Jurgens (*Randomized Author Order*)

ACL 2026 Findings | Project Leader [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#) [\[Twitter\]](#)

[9] **Logit Arithmetic Elicits Long Reasoning Capabilities Without Training**

Yunxiang Zhang, Muhammad Khalifa, [Lechen Zhang](#), Xin Liu, Ayoung Lee, Xinliang Frederick Zhang, Farima Fatahi Bayat, Lu Wang

ACL 2026 Findings | ScalR Workshop @ COLM 2025 | Main Contributor [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)

[8] **VeriFact: Enhancing Long-Form Factuality Evaluation with Refined Fact Extraction and Reference Facts**

Xin Liu, [Lechen Zhang](#), Sheza Munir, Yiyang Gu, Lu Wang

EMNLP 2025 | Main Contributor [\[ACL Anthology\]](#) [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)

[7] **FactBench: A Dynamic Benchmark for In-the-Wild Language Model Factuality Evaluation**

Farima Fatahi Bayat, [Lechen Zhang](#), Sheza Munir, Lu Wang

ACL 2025 Oral | Main Contributor [\[ACL Anthology\]](#) [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#) [\[Twitter\]](#)

- [6] **Towards Global AI Inclusivity: A Large-Scale Multilingual Terminology Dataset (GIST)**
Jiarui Liu*, Iman Ouzzani*, Wenkai Li*, Lechen Zhang, Tianyue Ou, Houda Bouamor, Zhijing Jin, Mona Diab
ACL 2025 Findings [\[ACL Anthology\]](#) [\[arXiv\]](#)
- [5] **Causally Modeling the Linguistic and Social Factors that Predict Email Response**
Yinuo Xu*, Hong Chen*, Sushrita Rakshit*, Aparna Ananthasubramaniam*, Omkar Yadav*, Mingqian Zheng*, Michael Jiang*, Lechen Zhang*, Bowen Yi*, Kenan Alkiek*, Abraham Israeli*, Bangzhao Shu*, Hua Shen*, Jiaxin Pei*, Haotian Zhang*, Miriam Schirmer*, David Jurgens (*Randomized Author Order*)
NAACL 2025 | Main Contributor [\[ACL Anthology\]](#)
- [4] **You don't need a personality test to know these models are unreliable: Assessing the Reliability of Large Language Models on Psychometric Instruments**
Bangzhao Shu*, Lechen Zhang*, Minje Choi, Lavinia Dunagan, Lajanugen Logeswaran, Moontae Lee, Dallas Card, David Jurgens
NAACL 2024 Oral | Project Leader [\[ACL Anthology\]](#) [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Slides\]](#) [\[Code\]](#) [\[Twitter\]](#)

Papers Under Review & Preprints

- [3] **Re-Centering Humans in LLM Personalization**
Lechen Zhang, Jiarui Liu, Tal August
Preprint | Project Leader [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)
- [2] **MixSD: Mixed Contextual Self-Distillation for Knowledge Injection**
Jiarui Liu, Lechen Zhang, Yongjin Yang, Yinghui He, Yingheng Wang, Weihao Xuan, Zhijing Jin, Mona Diab
Preprint | Main Contributor [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)
- [1] **Cross-Lingual Prompt Steerability: Towards Accurate and Robust LLM Behavior across Languages**
Lechen Zhang*, Yusheng Zhou*, Tolga Ergen, Lajanugen Logeswaran, Moontae Lee, David Jurgens
Preprint | Project Leader [\[arXiv\]](#) [\[Code\]](#)

PRESENTATIONS

EMNLP 2025 Poster (Suzhou) – *VeriFact: Enhancing Long-Form Factuality Evaluation with Refined Fact Extraction and Reference Facts.* [\[ACL Anthology\]](#)

NAACL 2024 Oral (Mexico City) – *You don't need a personality test to know these models are unreliable: Assessing the Reliability of Large Language Models on Psychometric Instruments.* [\[Slides\]](#) [\[ACL Anthology\]](#)

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES

Conference Reviewer

- EMNLP 2024 (*Outstanding Reviewer*), EMNLP 2025, EMNLP 2026
- EACL 2026 (*Outstanding Reviewer*)
- ACL 2025, ACL 2026
- NAACL 2025
- NLP+CSS Workshop @ NAACL 2024, ScalR Workshop @ COLM 2025, MATH-AI Workshop @ NeurIPS 2025, NLP+CSS Workshop @ ACL 2026

SKILLS

Programming: Python, C/C++, C#, Java, Go, SQL, MATLAB, R, Kotlin, LaTeX

Frameworks: PyTorch, Tensorflow, Transformers, Accelerate, DeepSpeed, PEFT, NLTK, Scikit-Learn

Languages: Chinese (Native), English (Fluent), Japanese (Basic)